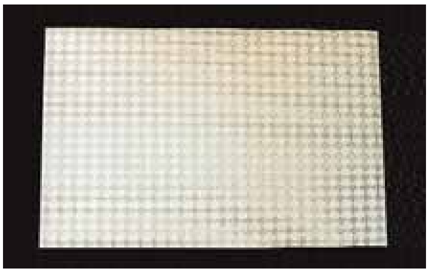
to its poor showing in the Local, Symmetric and Asymmetric Regulation tests. There was far too much distortion in images with sudden increase in brightness.

Sharpness and Resolution

If design is your forte then your monitor should also be able to reproduce sharp images at high resolutions. We tested the monitors for sharpness and resolution through a set of tests in which seven different images were generated on each monitor. The outcome of this test is a clear indicator for those who work with



This is the test screen for sharpness and resolution

page layout software, image editing software and other specialised design tools.

For 15-inch monitors, a score of 17 points and above in the Sharpness and Resolution test should be considered good. Here, Samtel SV-410 was clearly the best performer as it scored 20.6 points overall in this test. It did especially well in the Vertical Bar Resolution test in which the gaps between the bars could be clearly seen and there was very little moiré visible. Viewsonic E-53 came close behind in this test.

The Krypton 500LR performed poorly in this test. Even at full resolution it showed the bar as a solid block and the corners in the fine resolution matrix and diagonal matrix appeared very unclear—instead of showing a pure white line, the RGB component was clearly visible throughout. This clearly indicates that on this monitor one will not be able to view an object with great clarity.

As for 17-inch monitors, an overall score of 22 and above should be considered good. In this test, the monitor that came out trumps was again the Viewsonic G73f. It scored a handsome 27.1 points. Combined with its good showing in the Geometry test, this one makes a good choice for those who need to work with a lot of complicated 2D and 3D drawings at high resolutions. This model is a trifle expensive though.

Samsung SyncMaster 753DFX came out second best, scoring a neat 26. It performed exceptionally well in all the other subtests except for the Horizontal Bar Resolution test and the various resolution tests wherein its performance was just about acceptable.

The Samsung SyncMaster 753s performed brilliantly, scoring almost on par (25.8) with its more expensive cousin. Considering its price, the Samsung SyncMaster 753s strikes the right balance between price and performance.

Most of the other monitors scored pretty decently too, with a fair number of them crossing the 22 mark. A surprising exception was the LG Flatron 700s; it scored only 11.

Among the 19-inch monitors, the Sony CPD-G420 once again emerged as the winner, scoring maximum marks in all the tests except for the Horizontal Bar

Samsung SyncMaster 753s (17-inch)

Resolution test where it took a slight beating. Viewsonic E90 came very close to Sony by achieving a score of 25.1. Considering that it is priced at only Rs 21,500, it surely deserves more than a second look.

The Philips 109s lost a lot of points due to its rather average performance in the Resolution tests, especially in the Horizontal Bar Resolution test.

In the premium category (21- and 22-inch), one should expect nothing less than 26 in the Sharpness and Resolution test. With high-quality tubes and electronics, there was little where these behemoths could go wrong. All of them performed brilliantly and the competition was intense. Benq P211 and Philips 201B topped with a high score of 27.8. Viewsonic G810 came second with a score of 27.6. Yet, it beats the top performers in this test if you consider the price—a good Rs 15,000 to Rs 20,000 cheaper. The flatter Viewsonic P220F surprisingly failed to live up to expectations here, scoring only 25.

Screen Pixel Resolution

Once again, this aspect is especially important in applications where geometric shapes need to be generated. Even the highest resolution systems available will show some limitations, which in turn would result in jagged lines, inability to discriminate between closely spaced lines and

Go Easy on the Eyes

For anyone who spends more than a couple of hours a day in front of a computer, eyestrain is an important consideration. A good monitor not only generates more vibrant and 'real' looking images, but it is also much easier on the eyes. There are several factors that impact the eye-friendliness of a monitor.

Resolution: This refers to the sharpness and clarity of an image. For monitors, the screen resolution is expressed as number of dots (pixels) on the entire screen. This means that a 640x480 pixel (or VGA) screen is capable of displaying 640 distinct dots on each of the 480 lines, which translates to about 300,000 pixels. Make sure that you choose a resolution setting that you are comfortable with—a 1024x768 resolution on a 15-inch screen might not be very comfortable to view even if your monitor supports it.

Refresh rate: This is the rate at which each pixel is redrawn on a screen. If you view an image at lower refresh rates (say, 60 Hz), the images will flicker, causing eye-strain. The ideal setting for flicker-free viewing is about 85 Hz, but 75 Hz is comfortable too. Make sure that your monitor supports a refresh rate of at least 75 Hz. If you have a powerful graphics card that can generate images at high-resolutions and refresh rates, make sure that your monitor is able to support them.

Radiation: Long hours spent in front of a monitor can cause damage to one's eyes and in some cases even cause severe headaches. While modern CRT displays abide by the new (and stricter) emission standards, it would still be advisable to use an anti-glare screen to further eliminate electromagnetic radiation (EMR) from the display.